

Helping labor realize its second aim is no less important.

To satisfy labor's desire for recognition, management must give it just that. Management must show that it appreciates the importance of the individuals who actually perform the work. The responsibility and capacity for accomplishing this rests, largely, with the individual executive who, to the worker, represents and even personifies management.

I never cease to be amazed by the numbers of executives who do not realize the value of personal contact with rank-and-file employees. In some companies, the only times a production worker is likely to see a high-level executive are during full-dress Army-style inspection tours or when company "brass" escort VIP visitors through the plant.

Oh, yes. Then there are the executive visits occasionally staged by the company's public-relations department. The scenario for such an expedition usually follows a routine something like this: At a given hour—generally in the late morning or midafternoon—an impeccably dressed vice-president and a covey of bustling retainers descend on the plant. The party hesitantly and cautiously picks its way along the aisles between the rows of unfamiliar, noisy machines and stops, say, in front of a lathe. The vice-president fidgets, adjusts his necktie, shoots his cuffs and self-consciously edges closer to the lathe. He tries to look interested in the work being done on the machine and pretends to talk to the lathe operator—whose name has just been whispered into his ear, and which he has garbled.

## **118**

Two or three photographers raise their cameras and focus on the dismal tableau. Flash bulbs flare, the vice-president mumbles something unintelligible—and he and his retinue beat a hasty retreat, returning to the pine-paneled peace and quiet of the company's downtown administrative offices.

A photograph of the vice-president and the lathe operator appears in the local paper the next day—and in the company's house organ the following week. "Mr. Wilbur Knowall, Bollix and Company's vice-president in charge of personnel maintains close contact with the firm's employees," the caption